wherein the US and China facilitated a dialogue between Afghanistan and Pakistan, and pushed Islamabad to bring the Afghan Taliban to the talking table.[12] It was a marked departure from India's unkind reaction to the six plus two process in the 1990s or the London conference in 2010. New Delhi was not feeling left out from Afghanistan anymore.

The bonhomie was short-lived. On 2 January 2016, four militants belonging to the United Jihad Council, a militant organisation based out of Pakistan-administered Kashmir (and allegedly supported by the Pakistani intelligence services), attacked the Pathankot Air Force Station, part of the western air command of the Indian Air Force, killing seven Indian security personnel, one civilian, and the four attackers.[13] Resulting in national outcry, and severe criticism of the government in mishandling the defence of the air base, the attack derailed the India-Pakistan thaw. Complicating the situation further, a former Indian naval officer, Kulbhushan Jadhav, was caught, allegedly, entering Pakistan via Iran. He gave a video recorded confession, parts of which were made publicly available by Pakistan, and declared that he was commissioned to the R&AW from the navy in 2003 and had opened a small business in Chabahar, Iran, from where he undertook subversive activities in Karachi and Balochistan.[14] Pakistan cried foul, for it had finally produced evidence of Indian covert involvement in attacks on its soil. India firmly rejected the video as a doctored enterprise, and rejected that Jadhav was a spy (though they accepted that he was an Indian naval officer and demanded consular access to him which was denied by Pakistan).[15] Whether Jadhav is indeed a spy who undertook subversive activities in Pakistan is yet to be established, but the incident raised many questions about the R&AW's operations in Pakistan, and threatened to compromise India's moral high ground vis-à-vis Pakistan.

More worryingly for India, failed deliberations over the Pathankot attack and the Kulbhushan Jadhav case, were accompanied by popular unrest in Kashmir. On 8 July 2016, the Indian army had killed a young Kashmiri militant belonging to the Hizbul Mujahideen (and social media icon) Burhan Wani in an operation.[16] The Kashmir valley erupted in protests, leading to more police firing, and even more deaths and injuries. More than fifty protestors, and two policemen were killed, whereas pellets and rubber bullets wounded nearly 674 persons in a